

Synthetic Realness

Canonical Concept Paper

A. Jacobs | Reality Drift Framework

Canonical Definition

Synthetic Realness is a condition in which an optimized representation produces stronger signals of credibility, completeness, or authenticity than the less legible reality it represents.

It emerges when systems of curation, performance, and algorithmic mediation maximize coherence, fluency, polish, and emotional plausibility while reducing contextual grounding. The representation need not be wholly fabricated. Its force comes from the mismatch between perceptual credibility and evidentiary contact.

What Makes It Distinct

Synthetic Realness builds on themes explored in hyperreality and performance theory. Those frameworks describe simulation and staged identity as cultural phenomena.

By contrast, this concept identifies a perceptual inversion produced by optimization, in which signals refined for coherence and polish can appear more authentic than the realities they represent. As polish becomes a design target, resonance can substitute for grounding, shifting authenticity from lived context toward coherence and emotional plausibility.

Over time, trust migrates toward optimized representations rather than the realities they depict.

Mechanism

Modern media and algorithmic systems are optimized for fluency, predictability, and low friction. This optimization interacts with several well-documented cognitive tendencies:

- Information that is easier to process is judged as more truthful.
- Coherent narratives feel more reliable than fragmented ones.
- Emotional alignment increases perceived authenticity.
- Repetition increases familiarity and trust.

Because polished outputs reduce ambiguity and cognitive effort, they generate a stronger sense of certainty than unfiltered reality, which is often uneven and incomplete.

At scale, systems increasingly refine signals for coherence and emotional calibration, while lived experience remains irregular and context-dependent. As fluency becomes a dominant cue in judgment, polished representations gain an advantage in perceived credibility.

How It Shows Up

Synthetic Realness is visible across contemporary life:

- AI-generated content that feels more authoritative than human writing.
- Influencer personas that appear more authentic than everyday experience.
- Corporate messaging that feels more “real” than internal realities.
- Edited media that feels more compelling than unfiltered events.

Over time, these dynamics reshape perceptions of authenticity, favoring optimized representations over unfiltered experience.

Cross-Domain Effects

Synthetic Realness extends across multiple domains.

Psychology / Neuroscience: Fluency bias increases trust in polished signals, even when contextual grounding is limited.

AI / Technology: Generative systems produce coherent outputs that are judged authoritative despite limited reference to lived consequence.

Education: Students may favor polished summaries over primary materials, mistaking smoothness for depth.

Work / Organizations: Presentation quality shapes perception of truth more than operational substance.

Culture / Media: Engineered authenticity outcompetes imperfect lived expression, subtly reshaping standards of selfhood and performance.

Theoretical Context

Synthetic Realness sits adjacent to:

- The concept of hyperreality
- Performance theory
- Research on fluency bias

It extends these ideas by examining how optimization reshapes the cues through which authenticity is judged. Rather than focusing solely on simulation, it highlights how algorithmically mediated environments recalibrate perception toward fluency, coherence, and emotional plausibility.

Relationship to Reality Drift

The Drift Principle states that representations can be compressed, optimized, distributed, and reused faster than real-world conditions can correct them. Drift increases when a system's capacity to transform and circulate representations exceeds its capacity to test and revise them against their referents.

Synthetic Realness is the perceptual expression of Reality Drift. Optimized signals gain credibility as coherence increasingly substitutes for contextual grounding. A representation can therefore feel more trustworthy even as its connection to the reality it depicts grows weaker.

Practical Mitigations

Because Synthetic Realness is structural, mitigation requires both design and cognitive awareness:

- Preserving contextual signals alongside polished outputs
- Increasing transparency around mediation and generation
- Rewarding depth rather than surface coherence
- Creating environments that tolerate imperfection and friction
- Strengthening fidelity between representation and consequence

These interventions rebalance coherence with grounding.

In One Sentence

Synthetic Realness is the condition in which optimized representations feel more credible, complete, or authentic than the less polished realities they represent.